

THE SQUARE MOVES

LIKE THE GAME OF CHESS ITSELF, LIVE STREAMING ON OTT PLATFORMS CAN BE AN UPHILL TASK. BUT NOT IF YOU CROSS THE STRATEGIC PROWESS OF A COMMUNITY OF GMS AND IMs WITH THE EASE OF STREAMING AVAILABLE TODAY

BY **PRANAY PRAKASH** ILLUSTRATION BY **NILANJAN DAS**

I **MAGINE AN ODDLY-SHAPED** but familiar square board game on your mobile screen, only this one is adorned with not two but four sets of 16 pieces. Each set is arranged neatly on the board's four sides, according to their colour—red, blue, yellow and green. Beside them is a smaller rectangular box divided into four spaces with as many faces peering in from them. There's another face hanging in a corner outside the rectangle, frantically checking to see if everything is in order.

What you see underway is a game of the new-age, OTT avatar of one of the world's oldest and stodgiest sports, chess, being played by four players for an audience on YouTube. The four peering faces, the players, are Indian Grandmaster (GM) Vidith Gujrathi with red pieces; GM Anish Giri from the Netherlands (blue